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EDUCATOR'S PORTFOLIO

PORTFOLIO: EVIDENCE OF TEACHING EXCELLENCE:

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TEACHING STATEMENT

There is a Latin proverb that translates to “By learning you will teach; by teaching you will learn.” Therefore, my most important goal is to create a learning environment that is conducive of active and evidence-based for everyone. This is true whether teaching formally or informally, and whether my audience consists of undergraduate students, graduate clinicians or even patients.

Another Native American saying that I learned during my teaching and clinical journey is “Tell me and I’ll forget. Show me, and I may not remember. Involve me, and I’ll understand.” Thus, my style of teaching evolved over the years to be more practical, experiential and occasionally humorous, which I believe leads to a collaborative learning process that benefits everyone involved.

Three very important elements in my educational philosophy; respect for the learner, appreciating different learning styles and continuous refinement of the teaching process. These elements are linked and how I use them to define my educational approach is outlined below.

Respect for the learner

In the teacher-learner dyad, each element influences the success of the educational encounter. Engaging the learner is critical. One must start by gauging the needs of the learner, tailoring the approach to the learner, and insuring a safe learning environment. A central goal is to encourage experimentation and taking chances. Consistent with this attitude of respect is my willingness to accept error and correct it quickly when it occurs. Honesty about expectations, successes and mistakes is the foundation for the respect that will insure optimal learning.

Appreciating different learning styles

As a teacher of undergraduate and graduate students, it is important to recognize and accept the diversity that is in our classrooms today. Although, there are obvious forms of diversity in classrooms like language and ethnic background differences, my focus is not on overcoming ethnic discrimination or working towards inclusion and understanding. On the contrary, I focus towards recognizing and appreciating the diversity of students as individual learners. By providing different learning opportunities for different learning styles, I can maximize learning potentials for my students as well as help my students to choose the learning techniques that work best for them.

Continuous refinement of the teaching process

I truly, believe that each teaching session is an experiment in blending unique learning needs and teaching methods. Further, assessment and evaluation are integral parts of the learning process that ensure quality and help prevent the same errors from occurring over time. Further, I believe that accepting feedback and respecting that people learn differently helps me in my continuous refinement of courses. In fact, without looking back at what I have done, I would not be informed about what I might do.

These three basic approaches to teaching are embodied in the active and reflective style of teaching I feel most comfortable with. I engage my students early on in the course syllabus planning; probe what they know, what they think and what is the best course of action. I continue to build on what they know and help them discover their own ability to become good clinicians. This approach empowers students to take responsibility in the learning process, regardless of their level of training.

STUDENT EVALUATION FOR COURSES TAUGHT OF EACH SEMESTER

Whether teaching in the US, Saudi Arabia, or the United Arab Emirates, the majority of my students have evaluated me positively. Frequently, students express their appreciation and request that I teach more courses. Indeed, I read students' evaluations every time, consider their suggestions and comments and try to improve my teaching method every semester. Although, these comments are generally positive, sometimes they bring to my attention areas that would improve the learning process.

TEACHING/WORKLOADS ASSIGNED TO THE FACULTY MEMBER & DIVERSITY OF COURSES

Since Joining UAEU as a faculty member in Fall 2018, my teaching load was heavy that included 19 different introductory as well as specialized graduate courses (8 UG, 7 MA, 4 PhD). Every semester the number of students that I taught and supervised between different classes was more 100.

Despite that heavy teaching load, I maintained high standards of teaching that involved hands on learning, class discussions, as well as group worksheets inside and outside the classroom. Further, I have utilized hybrid teaching (using Black Board) early on (before COVID-19 pandemic) to improve learning outcomes among my students.

METHODOLOGY AND DOCUMENTATION OF THE TEACHING PROCESS

- I use active learning to teach various courses which include role playing, lab visits, group worksheets/projects, presentations, and class discussion.
- I link my courses to the latest developments and resources in the field (Special Education Lab, Neuroscience of Education Lab, new scientific information, videos)
- I prepare electronic file for each course that include the course content, such as: syllabus, power point presentations, quizzes and tests and students' homework and presentations. I upload the course syllabus and power points to students on blackboard at the beginning of each semester before class starts.
- I update my courses portfolio on blackboard and share my course materials with my colleagues who teach same courses.

- Since Spring 2020 and the lockdown due to COVID 19, I have been, successfully, teaching 100% online. Therefore, needed to add more discussions as well as a virtual lab to my classes instead of physical lab visits as well as the use of in-session polls and multiple-choice questions to keep the students engaged as much as possible.

DEVELOPMENT OF COURSE CONTENT

My broad field is communication disorders (Speech Language Pathology), however, my main area of interest is neuroscience and motor speech disorders. Since joining UAEU, I was engaged in teaching different courses that helped graduate and undergraduate students in the field of education analyze how the brain work and combine different aspects of knowledge. I was involved in the preparation of multiple doctoral level course contents. Additionally, I was involved in updating the content of several undergraduate courses. Further, I developed a hybrid course in 2019 with additional online content and activities to maximize student learning outside the classroom.

I contributed to developing and updating the content of following courses:

Graduate Courses:

- Language and Literacy Impairment (Doctoral level)
- Characteristics & Teaching Techniques for Individuals with Mild Disabilities (MA level)
- Advanced Collaboration (MA level)

Undergraduate Courses:

- Voice Disorders
- Neurology for Speech Language Pathology
- Introduction to Communication Sciences and Disorders
- Dysphagia
- Assistive technology for Children with Disabilities
- Early Intervention
- Individuals with Mild Moderate Disabilities
- Introduction to Rehabilitation
- Language & Communication Disorders Class

USE OF AND DEVELOPMENT OF MODERN TEACHING METHODS AND TECHNIQUES

As noted in my teaching statement earlier, I try to make my classes more interactive and hands-on by using group projects, discussion, and presentation prepared by students.

Presentations and self-learning. In specific graduate level courses, students are requested to prepare and present some of the course chapters. I feel this is very important learning experience for them, they become the instructors and they prepare their own power points presentations, which should not depend only on the textbook.

For example, in one of my phd classes, each student is required to present, prepare and lead the class in a discussion of a major area of study regarding in-depth topics related to language and literacy. Students will provide an outline of the major issues along with a series of discussion questions for the class. They are required to lead that session. In class group worksheets and activities were designed and used to engage students in active learning and problem solving in the assistive technology class.

Discussion. I always encourage my students to discuss course information. Brain is the biggest enigma, most of the students find themselves thinking critically about different methods for brain rehabilitation and recovery. Or even a different analysis for the neuropsychological symptoms discussed.

An example is the use of cutting-edge neuroscience technology to guide education. Since I established the neuroscience of education lab at the college of education, MA and PhD students have been exposed to the learning process from a neuroscience perspective. Multiple discussions with my MA and PhD student occurred around that topic.

Use of Technology. The use of technology in education is a very beneficial tool. It extends learning process beyond the classroom and support the retention of information longer. An example would be the use of hybrid teaching (using BlackBoard). I transformed a class to be a hybrid class in 2019 before even the online teaching was a must following the COVID-19 pandemic. Therefore, when we as faculty and researchers were required to provide 100% online teaching I was comfortable and confident in adapting all of my courses to be 100% online using different tools that are available to us as faculty.

CONTRIBUTION OF THE DEVELOPMENT OF ACADEMIC PROGRAMS, CURRICULA AND COURSES

Since Joining UAEU in 2018, I believe that I made significant contribution to the development of several programs, including the phd in SPED program, developing a comprehensive proposal that lead to establishing a BS in Speech Language Pathology and the another proposal to establish a master's clinical program in Speech Language Pathology as well as coordinating the development of a Phd in rehabilitation sciences. Further, I was involved in other smaller curricular development duties such as proposing a new manuscript style dissertation for the Phd in education program, as well as developing hands-on practicum tasks in several undergraduate SPED course.

PREPARATION OF APPROPRIATE EXAMINATION AND THE DEVELOPMENT OF EFFECTIVE STUDENT EVALUATION TOOLS

I believe examination should reflect students' understanding rather than memorization. I use a variety of grading tools, which differs from one course to another.

- Multiple choice and short answer tests
- Quizzes
- Hands-on worksheets. These were used in the Assistive technology class as well as Anatomy and Physiology topics in the Communication Disorders Class.
- Discussion: I ask students to discuss different course related issues. For example, in my doctoral language and literacy disorders course, students are asked to investigate and discuss the effectiveness/side effects of different intervention approaches related to communication disorders.
- Reports: students are required to write short reports about course related issues. Students can compare/ explain or write a small essay about their chosen topic.

INTERACTION WITH STUDENTS AND ENCOURAGING THEM TO DEVELOP THEIR SKILLS & ENHANCE THEIR SELF- LEARNING CAPABILITIES

I have always advocated for students; I believe I was lucky because I was blessed with smart graduate and undergraduate students.

- I try to be available for them, approachable and considerate. Students have my mobile number and can send me WhatsApp messages.
- Update students with their grades and how to improve them.
- Advising the students, as a faculty member who have undergraduate and graduate advisees.
- Co-published papers in Scopus indexes journals with an MA student and another one with a phd student.
- Supported undergraduate and graduate students through providing them with financial support as RAs in my neuroscience of education lab.
- Assigned computers for the graduate students and provided them with access to the neuroscience of education lab and equipment in addition to providing training to them.
- Provided reviews and recommendation to graduate students who are not directly under my supervision through reviewing their surveys, assessment instruments as well as manuscript feedback.
- Provided additional supportive services in the SPED lab by training and supervising students on how to use assessment tools related to language and communication disorders.

SUPERVISION OF GRADUATION PROJECTS AND SEMINARS

- Supervised 5 undergraduate students for their Research Project to develop an Early Identification Autism Assessment that can be used in the Emirati society
- Supervised 1 PhD students
- Co-supervised 1 PhD student
- Supervised 5 Master students
- Co-supervised 2 MS student

DISSEMINATION OF TEACHING PRACTICES TO COLLEAGUES

I always share my teaching materials with new faculty members who are teaching the same course. I provided hands on training to new faculty members in relation to how to use BB as well as LOAMS.

Provided Neuroscience related continuing education workshops to colleagues who are interested in learning about the cutting-edge noninvasive neuroimaging technology in the neuroscience of education lab.

PUBLICATIONS IN PEER REVIEWED JOURNALS OF INTERNATIONAL STANDING

I have 18 published research articles in Scopus indexed journals (Q1,Q2,Q3, Q4), 1 in a PubMed/ISI indexed journal, and 1 in a Q1 ARCIF indexed journal. Many of these papers were in educational journal related to special needs or rehabilitation.

Currently, I have 4 manuscripts under review in Scopus indexed educational and rehabilitation journals.

PRESENTATIONS AT INTERNATIONAL EDUCATIONAL CONFERENCES

The following is a list of conference presentations in international educational and rehabilitation conferences

- El Azab, E., **Safi, M.** June 28th, 2021. Cortical activation as a Result of Reading Stimuli for students with dyslexia and typically developing: New Insights from functional Near Infrared Spectroscopy Neuroimaging (fNIRS). UAE Graduate Students Research Conference 2021 (UAEGSRC'2021),
- Alnuaimi, M., **Safi, M.** June 12, 2021. Digital Social Stories and ASD Children. 5th Canadian International Conference on Advances in Education, Teaching & Technology 2021.
- **Safi, M. (May 25, 2021). Speaker/Moderator.** Voice Disorders & COVID-19. Emirate Society for Speech Language Pathology. Virtual Symposium.
- **Safi, M. (May 25, 2021). Speaker/Moderator.** Developmental Aphasia. Emirate Society for Speech Language Pathology. Virtual Symposium.
- **Safi, M. (April 10, 2021). Speaker.** The Effectiveness of Using Tele practice in Clinical Education: A Review from Dar Al Hekma University. 11th Emirates Otorhinolaryngology Audiology and Communication Disorders Congress. Virtual Symposium.
- **Safi, M. (Oct/2019). Speaker.** My Voice is My Power. Sharjah Learning Disabilities Conference. Sharjah Humanitarian City. Sharjah, UAE.
- **Safi, M. (Sept/2019). Keynote Speaker.** Effect of NMES Modality on Swallowing. UAE ENT & SLP Conference. UAE Medical Society. UAE.
- **Safi, M. (July/2019). Speaker.** Neuromuscular Electrical Stimulation effect on Facial Weakness. American Speech Language Hearing Association Conference. Chicago, USA.
- **Safi, M. (April/2016). Speaker.** *The Role of Different Medical Rehabilitation Specialties in the Management of Dysphagia.* College of Applied Medical Sciences Conference.
- **Safi, M., Wright-Harp, W., Luckner, J. & Payne, J. (April/2014). Speaker.** *Effect of neuromuscular electrical stimulation on lingual, labial & buccal muscles.* ASHA Health Care Conference. Las Vegas, NV.
- **Safi, M., Wright-Harp, W., & Luckner, J. (March/2014). Speaker.** *A Review of the Effect of neuromuscular electrical stimulation on facial and lingual muscles.* DCSHA Annual Conference. Rockville, MD.
- **Safi, M., Martin, S., Wright-Harp, W. & Ludlow, C. (June/ 2010). Speaker.** *Evaluation of submental stimulation in healthy volunteers.* Oral technical session presentation. Integrative Neural Systems Underlying Vital, Aerodigestive Tract Functions Conference, Madison, WI.
- **Safi, M., Martin, S., Wright-Harp, W. & Ludlow, C. (April/ 2010). Speaker.** *Effect of Submental Electrical Stimulation on Hyolaryngeal Elevation.* Graduate Research Symposium. Howard University. Washington, DC.
- **Safi, M. (October/2004). Speaker.** *Neurogenic Language & Communication Disorders.* 1st Regional Rehabilitation Symposium.

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This shared folder includes the following items:

1. Educator's Portfolio
2. Summary of Self-Assessment
3. Student Evaluation
4. Faculty appraisal
5. Sample Syllabi
6. Research Portfolio
7. Other achievements in the area of scholarship
8. Service Portfolio
9. Professional Development